

# 94 Isaiah

*The prophet who saw the Lord high and lifted up, and spoke of judgment, comfort and a coming King.*

Isaiah son of Amoz prophesied in Jerusalem for about forty years or more, through the reigns of four kings of Judah. His ministry began with a vision of God's holiness in the temple, and his answer, "Here am I; send me," has echoed through the centuries. He confronted King Ahaz when fear drove him toward Assyria. He stood beside King Hezekiah when the Assyrian army surrounded Jerusalem. He warned of judgment on Judah and the nations, yet he also spoke some of Scripture's most tender words of comfort. His book looks ahead to a child called Immanuel, a Prince of Peace, and a suffering servant wounded for others. The New Testament quotes him more than any other prophet.

## At a glance

|               |                                                                                                              |
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| Name          | Hebrew <i>Yeshayahu</i> , "the LORD saves"                                                                   |
| Family        | Son of Amoz; married to "the prophetess"; sons Shear-jashub and Maher-shalal-hash-baz (Isaiah 1:1; 7:3; 8:3) |
| When          | Days of Uzziah, Jotham, Ahaz and Hezekiah, c. 740–c. 680 BC (Isaiah 1:1)                                     |
| Key places    | Jerusalem; the temple; the upper pool                                                                        |
| Key people    | Ahaz, Hezekiah, Sennacherib's officer the Rabshakeh                                                          |
| Main passages | Isaiah 1–66; 2 Kings 19–20; 2 Chronicles 26:22; 32:20, 32                                                    |
| New Testament | Quoted often, as "Esaias" (for example Matthew 3:3; Luke 4:17–19; John 12:38–41; Acts 8:28–35)               |

*"Also I heard the voice of the Lord, saying, Whom shall I send, and who will go for us? Then said I, Here am I; send me."*

Isaiah 6:8, KJV

# The life of Isaiah

Dates are approximate (BC). The events of Isaiah 38–39 are placed around 701 BC because Hezekiah was given fifteen more years. Some date them a little earlier.

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|-----------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <p><b>c. 740 BC</b><br/><i>Year Uzziah died</i></p>       | <p>● <b>The vision and call</b><br/>Isaiah sees the Lord on a throne and seraphim crying, "Holy, holy, holy." A live coal touches his lips, and he answers God's call. <i>Isaiah 6:1–13</i></p>                                 |
| <p><b>c. 735 BC</b><br/><i>Reign of Ahaz</i></p>          | <p>● <b>The sign of Immanuel</b><br/>Syria and Israel threaten Jerusalem. Isaiah meets Ahaz at the upper pool with his son and urges him to trust God. He gives the sign of a child called Immanuel. <i>Isaiah 7:1–16</i></p>   |
| <p><b>c. 734 BC</b><br/><i>Soon after</i></p>             | <p>● <b>A son as a sign</b><br/>His wife bears a son named Maher-shalal-hash-baz. Before the boy can talk, Assyria will plunder Damascus and Samaria. <i>Isaiah 8:1–4</i></p>                                                   |
| <p><b>c. 711 BC</b><br/><i>Year of Ashdod</i></p>         | <p>● <b>Walks barefoot</b><br/>When Assyria attacks Ashdod, Isaiah goes stripped and barefoot for three years. It is a sign that Egypt and Ethiopia will be led away captive. <i>Isaiah 20:1–6</i></p>                          |
| <p><b>c. 701 BC</b><br/><i>Sennacherib's invasion</i></p> | <p>● <b>God will defend the city</b><br/>Hezekiah sends to him in distress. Isaiah answers that the Assyrian king will not enter Jerusalem. That night the angel of the LORD strikes the camp. <i>2 Kings 19:1–7, 20–37</i></p> |
| <p><b>c. 701 BC</b><br/><i>Hezekiah's illness</i></p>     | <p>● <b>Death, then life</b><br/>Isaiah tells the king to set his house in order. After Hezekiah prays, Isaiah brings word of fifteen more years and a sign on the sundial. <i>2 Kings 20:1–11; Isaiah 38:1–8</i></p>           |
| <p><b>c. 701 BC</b><br/><i>Envoys from Babylon</i></p>    | <p>● <b>A warning of exile</b><br/>Hezekiah shows his treasures to visitors from Babylon. Isaiah foretells that everything will one day be carried there. <i>2 Kings 20:12–19; Isaiah 39:1–8</i></p>                            |

# Key activities

Many scholars think later prophets wrote or completed chapters 40–66; many others hold that Isaiah wrote the whole book.

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- I** **Saw God's holiness.** In the temple he saw the Lord "high and lifted up" and cried, "Woe is me! for I am undone." *Isaiah 6:1–5*

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  - 2** **Answered the call.** Cleansed by the live coal, he offered himself: "Here am I; send me." *Isaiah 6:6–8*

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  - 3** **Called for justice.** He told Judah to relieve the oppressed. "Though your sins be as scarlet, they shall be as white as snow." *Isaiah 1:16–18*

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  - 4** **Challenged a frightened king.** He urged Ahaz to trust God instead of foreign powers. "If ye will not believe, surely ye shall not be established." *Isaiah 7:1–9*

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  - 5** **Gave signs through his family.** He said that he and his children were "for signs and for wonders in Israel." *Isaiah 7:3; 8:1–4, 18*

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  - 6** **Foretold a royal child.** A child would be born, called Wonderful, Counsellor, the mighty God, the everlasting Father, the Prince of Peace. *Isaiah 9:6–7; 11:1–10*

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  - 7** **Acted out a warning.** He walked barefoot for three years to warn against trusting Egypt. *Isaiah 20:2–6*

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  - 8** **Strengthened Hezekiah.** When Jerusalem was besieged, he told the king not to be afraid and prayed with him. *2 Kings 19:6–7; 2 Chronicles 32:20*

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  - 9** **Brought news of healing.** He announced Hezekiah's death, then his recovery. *2 Kings 20:1–7*

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  - 10** **Recorded history.** He wrote the acts of Uzziah and of Hezekiah. *2 Chronicles 26:22; 32:32*

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  - II** **Spoke comfort.** "Comfort ye, comfort ye my people, saith your God." *Isaiah 40:1–11, 28–31*

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  - 12** **Described the suffering servant.** "He was wounded for our transgressions, he was bruised for our iniquities." *Isaiah 52:13–53:12*

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# Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links, not places that name Isaiah.

## Old Testament

|                                       |                                                  |
|---------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------|
| Isaiah 1–66                           | His book of prophecy, history (36–39) and poetry |
| 2 Kings 19–20; 2 Chronicles 32:20, 32 | His part in Hezekiah's reign                     |
| 2 Chronicles 26:22                    | He wrote an account of Uzziah's reign            |
| Echo: Micah 4:1–3                     | Swords into plowshares, as in Isaiah 2:2–4       |
| Echo: Jeremiah 1:9; Ezekiel 2:8–3:4   | God puts his words in their mouths               |

## New Testament

|                 |                                                           |
|-----------------|-----------------------------------------------------------|
| Matthew 1:22–23 | Isaiah 7:14 fulfilled; some see a first fulfilment too    |
| Matthew 3:3     | John is "the voice of one crying in the wilderness"       |
| Luke 4:16–21    | In Nazareth Jesus reads Isaiah 61:1–2 as fulfilled        |
| John 12:38–41   | Isaiah saw Christ's glory and spoke of him                |
| Acts 8:28–35    | From Isaiah 53, Philip preaches Jesus                     |
| Tradition       | Later writings say he was sawn in two (cf. Hebrews 11:37) |

## For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Isaiah see and hear before he said, "Here am I; send me" (Isaiah 6:1–8)?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think a vision of God's holiness made Isaiah feel "undone" before it made him ready to serve?
3. *Apply:* Ahaz trusted a powerful ally more than God. What do you lean on when you are afraid?
4. *Apply:* Isaiah spoke hard truth and deep comfort. Who needs one of those from you this week?